

KARNATAKA

B.S.
Yeddyurappa



WHO IS TO BLAME

"The wrong UPA policies that are disconnected from the *aam admi* and the blame-game."

WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE

"Redress the real issues of farmers and be more proactive to improve output."

The GUJARAT Model

On the surface it looks like a paradox. When agricultural production in most other states is plummeting, Gujarat, with large semi-arid tracts that were alien to good crops, offers a turnaround story. Last year, it posted an agricultural growth of 9.6 per cent against a national average of 2.9 per cent. The state's annual agro output (including production from animal husbandry) now revolves around Rs 49,000 crore, from just Rs 18,000 crore in 2000-01.

The figures are impressive even after factoring in a reasonably steady monsoon ever since Chief Minister Narendra Modi took over in 2001-end. As leading agriculture scientist M.S. Swaminathan puts it, "Gujarat owes it to a scientific and integrated approach to agriculture during Narendra Modi's tenure which is backed by a sharp vision."

What impressed Swaminathan most was the Modi Government's decision to give soil health cards to farmers so that they could assess the quality of land. Steps were also taken to improve the quality of seeds, raise the groundwater table by building almost a lakh check dams

within a decade in Kutch, Saurashtra and north Gujarat besides extensive use of technology by bringing scientists and farmers on one platform.

Judicious use of water for farming got a major fillip in 2003 when the state Government floated the Gujarat Green Revolution Company to encourage drip irrigation. From 105 lakh hectares in 2000-2001, the state's cultivable area now stands at 120 lakh hectares. Plus, agro financing was done with a purpose. Gujarat Agricultural University was also split into four universities, each dedicated to a particular crop.

As Modi says, "We worked with a strategy and vision, and are reaping the fruits now." Japan recently placed a huge import order of organic til grown in Gujarat. Kutch, that never knew what Kesar mango was, now produces and exports it. Similarly, the region is now cultivating Arabian dates. The state increased its cotton yield sixfold in nine years from 175 kg per hectare to 798 kg, more than the world average of 787 kg. Gujarat's farmland is a field of glory now, giving reason for other states to take a leaf out of its success story.

by Uday Mahurkar



GUJARAT HAS ITS SECOND GREEN REVOLUTION

began research on hybrids in 1964 and average yield is 6,336 kg/ha. Today, scientists there are working on a strain that will deliver 13,500 kg/ha, having successfully achieved 10,500 kg/ha. If India were to develop a similar strain, Bihar alone would produce over 35 million tonnes or a third of India's current production. In terms of income, this would translate into (@Rs 30 per kg) Rs 2,04,750 as against Rs 28,275 per hectare as of now. Agriculture is a business. China has promoted contract farming for predictability of income and prices, delivering prosperity to a million farmers in partnership with Walmart. But that calls for a consensus among political parties which must also ensure that nobody does a Singur. Ditto with ideas like acquiring or leasing land overseas. Sudan has 89 million hectares of arable land of which it uses just 17 million hectares. Brazil uses only a third of its arable potential of 180 million hectares. Why shouldn't Indian companies lease land, produce pulses, oilseeds or sugar and this be treated as an SEZ for duty free imports? Price management needs to be divorced from the myth of Indian self-reliance.

Next week, the Congress Working Committee—which has met half a dozen times on food price inflation in recent times—is meeting again to discuss inflation. Once the fog lifts over Delhi, the prime minister plans to call a meeting of chief ministers on this emotive issue. It will be a good intersection to introduce new thoughts into the political economy. It will be a good time to lift the fog over policymaking. It is also a good time for a reality check. India has limited land and resources but it must deliver both food availability and affordability. Politicians need to accept this reality. Or our rural economy could easily be reduced to a dole economy.

with bureau inputs